

DELHI | 51 Ways to Lose Money

India will give France \$2.2 billion to upgrade its 51 Mirage 2000 fighter aircraft bought in the mid-1980s. The upgradation will be for new radars, weapons and a 20-year life extension. Each upgrade will cost \$40 million (Rs 200 crore), nearly the cost of a brand new Sukhoi-30.

by Sandeep Unnithan



- JAM-PROOF COMMUNICATION DATA LINKS
- HELMET MOUNTED DISPLAYS
- GLASS COCKPIT
- RADAR
- AIRFRAME LIFE EXTENSION BY 20 YEARS
- PRECISION TARGETING SYSTEMS
- NEW MISSILES

REUTERS

A POLICE-MAN'S CONSCIENCE UNCOVERS THE TRUTH IN A 40-YEAR-OLD "ENCOUNTER" KILLING.

KERALA | Appeal of Conscience

Judicial history was made when a trial began in the Special CBI court in Ernakulam of a 40-year-old case related to Kerala's most infamous "encounter death". In February 1970, "Naxal" Varghese, a prominent Naxalite leader, was found shot dead. The police claimed it was an encounter death. But in 1999, a retired police constable P. Ramachandran Nair filed an affidavit, saying he had shot Varghese on orders from his superiors. A 2002 CBI inquiry revealed that to be true. Nair died four years ago but his conscience triggered the truth.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

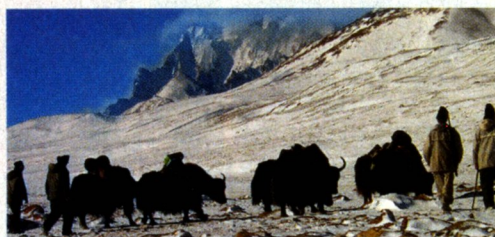
MUMBAI | Rite Way

In Mumbai, even the dead can be eco-friendly. An NGO has installed the city's first green crematorium in the suburb of Jogeshwari, with Brihan Mumbai Corporation's approval. A four-pyre installation, which consumes 75 per cent less wood and takes half the time to cremate a body, costs Rs 5 lakh per pyre to make while traditional pyres cost Rs 26 lakh each. The city will see five more such crematoriums over the next year.

by Mitali Patel

DELHI | The Yaks Effect

External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna may be spending a few days in Beijing on a visit to consolidate relations with the Chinese but on the ground, India's border forces are battling more than just bad weather and the adversary. The Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), 9,000 of whose personnel guard the 1,148-km Sikkim-Arunachal stretch of the Sino-Indian border, is struggling due to poor road connectivity. No jeeps or trucks can be put into service to carry equipment, rations, weapons or the men themselves. Ranjit Kumar Bhatia, ITBP director-general, says the problem has been eased somewhat by a four-legged force of 75 yaks. Also, two



YAKS CARRYING RATIONS

snowbikes are being tried out, and more are on their way. Ponies and horses have also been used but are not very effective in the high mountains. Plans to construct border roads in Arunachal Pradesh would take years to fructify. Until then, the yaks will have to soldier on.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora